

ATISH BUKREDIWALA, 29

Stock Broker, KOLKATA

He has gone online on his father's advice to open up a world of matrimonial choices. He is determined to fly in the face of community tradition and get married to a girl with at least a B.Com degree.

Family ties matter the most to him. He wants a girl who would understand him and his milieu. **"I don't need a girl with a well-cut face or a perfect figure."**



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allows people to sort out their search by the facial features they seek in a partner," he says. It also shows up the value-driven beauty quest. There's a clear preference among south Indian men, for instance, for women with a girl next-door look—modelled on actresses known to have an unpretentious demeanour.

Age is the other signpost that's shifting its threshold. Kiran Hosur, an auto engineer and businessman based in Bangalore, might be 36 years old, but he is looking for a mate between age 34 and 38. "I want companionship and that age group suits me fine." "Age is just a number," adds Anarkat. "Think of Abhi-Ash," he quips. "Although a gap of three to five years is commonly accepted by both men and women, the concept of age being just a number seems to click better with men than women," says Mittal. Indeed, the surveys show that the age band for the "suitable girl" is moving upwards.

In another remarkable twist, today's men seem to be looking at marriage in the same way as women have done from time immemorial. That is, as a passport to security and better lifestyle. And for that the average Indian man considers a bachelor's degree to be the minimum acceptable qualification for a wife. Dilip, a 24-year-old businessman in Mumbai, is clear about it: "In these times, everyone needs to be, at least, a graduate." Across the country in Kolkata, stock marketer, Atish Bukrediwalla is determined to fly in the face of community tradition and get married to a girl with a B.Com degree. "In the Marwari community, housewife oriented women are preferred. But I want someone more educated. That is the trend these days. Most of the women on the Net are qualified, working women." The power of the double-income family has men, especially in the metros, looking for working wives: doctor and engineer wives for lucrative career prospects, girls in the public sector for



Preferred Partner

A look at how the trend has changed*

1960's

Pretty, virgin, accomplished girl; right caste and family

1970's

Convent-educated, smart, fair, innocent girl

1980's

Tall, fair, slim, qualified and homely

1990's

High-earning, physically perfect plus homely

2000's

Compatible, educated working girl, looks not that important, nor caste and horoscope

42%

OF MEN SAY BEAUTY LIES IN THE EYE OF THE BEHOLDER

47%

OF MEN WANT EDUCATED GIRLS WHO WOULD CONTINUE TO WORK

*Source: Ranjana Kumari, 'Indian Marriages: Economic Independence & Changing Power Relations', 2004, Centre for Social Research, Delhi

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